Data for Resolutions Subcommittee

From Danielle Allen, DSC Member Middlesex & Suffolk

April 4, 2026

Primary Types

	Nebraska	Louisiana	California	Washington	Alaska	Massachusetts
NCSL Description	Nonpartisan	All-Comers, aka "Jungle Primary"	Multi-party (aka Top-Two)	Multi-party (aka Top-Two)	Multi-party (aka Top-Four)	If ballot initiative passes: All-party Primary (aka Top-Two)
Process	Top two vote-getters move to general election	If candidates get 50%+1 in primary, no general election	Top two vote-getters move to general regardless of party	Top two vote-getters move to general regardless of party	Top four vote-getters move to general regardless of party	Top two vote-getters move to general regardless of party
Candidate Party Registration or "Preference"	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Party Endorsements on the Ballot?	No	No	No	No	No	Yes
Voter Registration (June 2025)	Dem: 26.3% GOP: 49.6% Other / No Party: 24.1%	Dem: 36.8% GOP: 35.2% Other / No Party: 27.9%	Dem: 45.3% GOP: 25.2% Other / No Party: 29.5%	No party registration	Dem: 12.2% GOP: 24.4% Other / No Party: 64.71%	Dem: 25.8% GOP: 8.4% Other / No Party: 65.7%%

Top 2
Lock-out Data

Complete List of Lockout Elections 2008-2024 in CA and WA (2000+ elections)

2012 CA-31 U.S. House Race
Gary Miller (Incumbent, R) and Bob Dutton (R) advanced; incumbent Miller won
4 Democrats were in the race, no Democrat advanced
Democrats as a group did not receive majority of total vote across candidates, despite being a D+2 district

2016 Washington State Treasurer (statewide)
Open seat. Duane Davidson (R) and Michael Waite (R) advanced
3 Democrats were in race, no Democrat advanced
Washington is a Democratic-leaning statewide electorate

2022 California State Senate District 4
Open seat. Tim Robertson (D) and Marie Alvarado-Gil (D) advanced
8 Republicans were in the race and did not advance, despite as a group having the majority of votes

Nancy Pelosi on CA Gubernatorial- NYT

At the convention last weekend, California Democrats celebrated Ms. Pelosi as she neared retirement. But she made it clear that she still held sway as she tamped down concerns about the governor's race.

"We will have a Democratic governor for our state," Ms. Pelosi said in an interview. "And some reporters have said, 'Well, what about two Republicans?' That won't happen."

She said she had spoken to nearly all of the candidates for governor. While she has not endorsed anyone, she also did not tell any of them to drop out. But she firmly believed the field would sort itself out. "I'm very confident," she said. "I've done this a long time."

Fairness, Inclusion, and Participation Data

Key Research Findings

“The Top-2 led to a significant increase in voter turnout in California.” Crosson, Reforming Primary Elections (2026)

“The Top-2 encourages primary election participation.” Crosson, Reforming Primary Elections (2026)

“Voters in nonpartisan primary states (which include Top-2 primary states) are twelve percentage points more likely to turn out for primary elections than similar voters in other states.” Crosson, Reforming Primary Elections (2026)

“Nationwide, primary election turnout was 21.3% of eligible voters in 2022. But in Alaska, the only state with a top-four nonpartisan primary, 37% of eligible voters turned out for the primary. In Washington and California, two states with top-two nonpartisan primaries, primary turnout was 35% and 29%, respectively.” - Bipartisan Policy Center report on 2022 Midterms

“Individuals living in states with nonpartisan (or all-candidate) primaries—where Republicans and Democrats appear on a single ballot—were significantly more likely to vote.” – Donovan T, Micatka NK, Tolbert CJ ; PLoS One (2025)

“The proportion of registered voters supporting the ultimate winner in the final choice between Democrats is about three times greater with the top-two copartisan general elections than with the contested partisan primaries.” - Sinclair JA, O’Grady I, Miller B, Murphy CM. State Politics & Policy Quarterly (2026)

“Open and top-two primaries are associated with higher turnout from independent voters of color in both primary and general elections” – Centeno and Grose, The Demobilizing Effect of Primary Electoral Institutions on Voters of Color (April 2021).

Key Research Findings

“Primary voters are less representative of the pool of eligible voters than general election electorates are.” - Bipartisan Policy Center

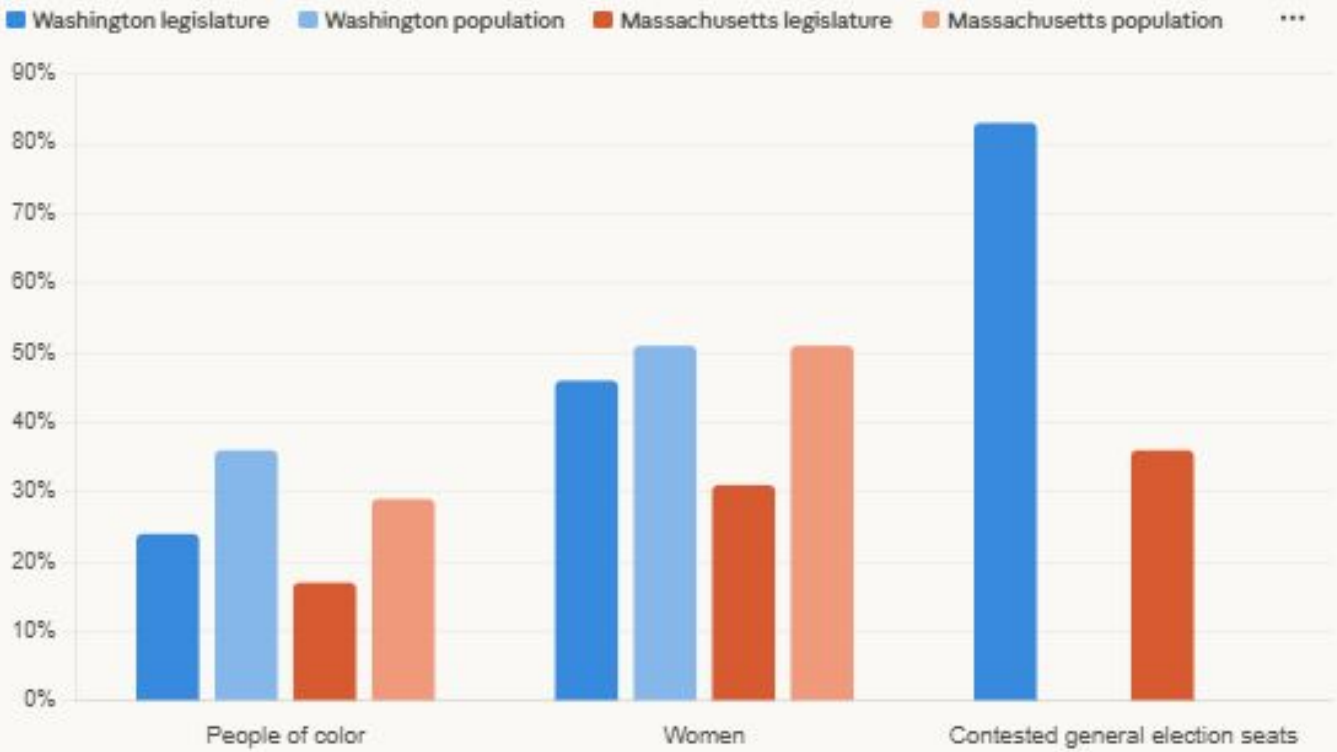
“Same-party elections bring some competition to places that otherwise would not have it. Winners must be accepted by a broad coalition and the potential for competitiveness means each member of the coalition is important.” Sinclair JA, O’Grady I, Miller B, Murphy CM. State Politics & Policy Quarterly (2026)

“Nonpartisan primaries produce the largest, most diverse constituency possible.” Monson, Reforming Primary Elections (2026)

“Broad-based elections check undue influence from political factions.” Monson, Reforming Primary Elections (2026)

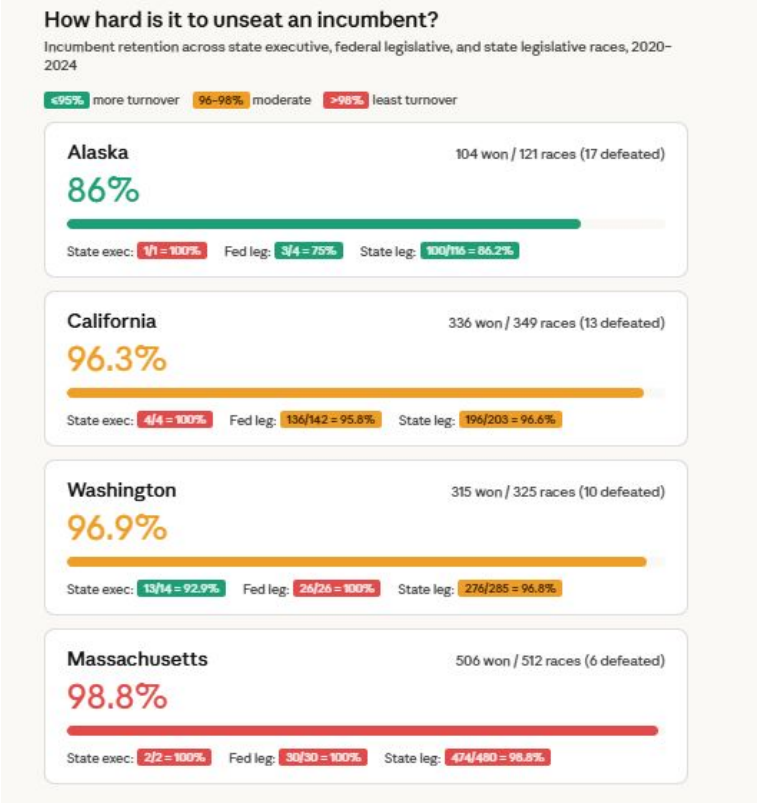
“The Top-2 primary exhibits effectiveness against extremism, operational reliability and practicality, and political feasibility.” Crosson, Reforming Primary Elections (2026)

WA and MA Legislature Diversity/Inclusion



Sources: WA diversity from Cascade PBS & WA Community Alliance (2022-2024); MA diversity from MA Women's Caucus (2025) & state reporting. WA competitiveness from Ballotpedia (2024); MA competitiveness provided by campaign. Population data from U.S. Census / WCA.

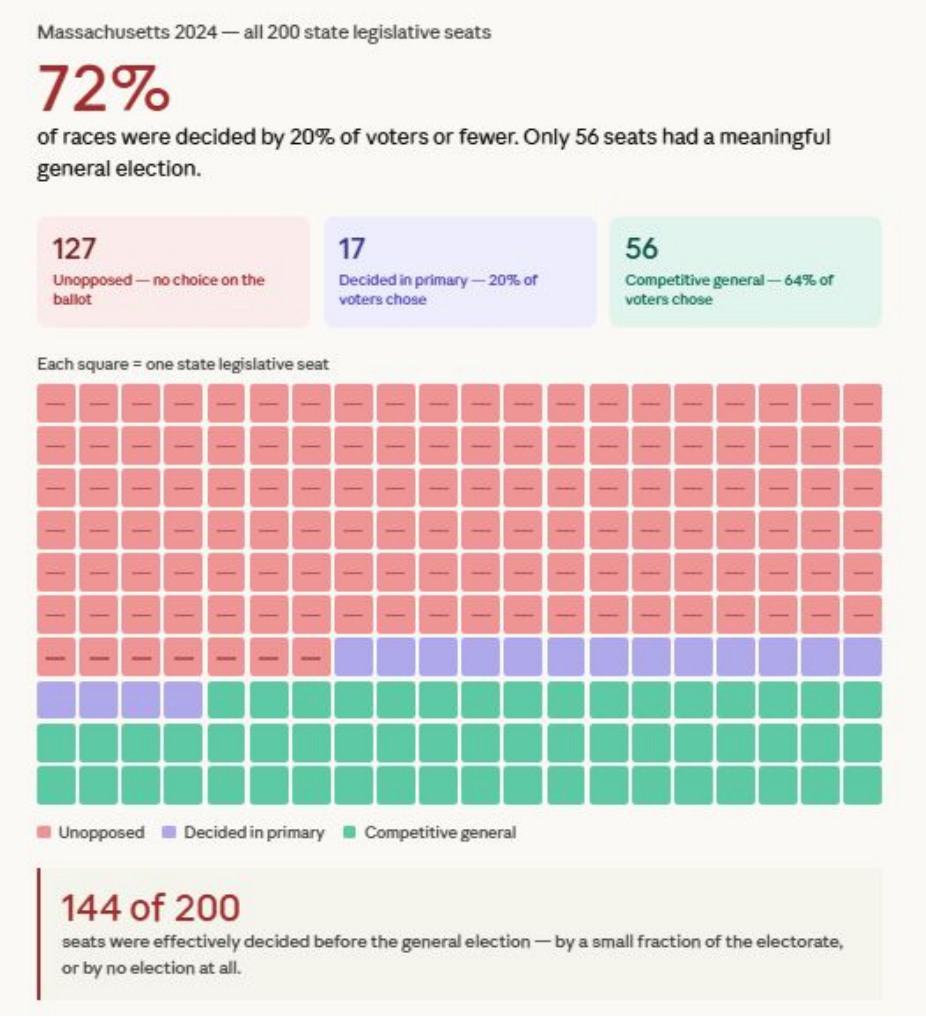
Incumbency Retention Rates



Alaska stands out clearly — across 121 races from 2020–2024, 17 incumbents lost, for an 86.0% retention rate. That's driven almost entirely by state legislative turnover (100 of 116 state leg incumbents won, or 86.2%), with the Peltola loss adding to it on the federal side.

California and Washington land in a similar band at 96.3% and 96.9%, both in the yellow zone. California's turnover comes from both federal (6 House members lost across three cycles) and state legislative races. Washington's comes mostly from state legislative churn and one state executive loss in 2020.

Massachusetts is the most locked-in at 98.8% — just 6 incumbents lost out of 512 races across the entire period, and all 6 were in the state legislature. No federal or statewide executive incumbent lost in any of the three cycles. Both California and Washington were in a similar place prior to their change.



Massachusetts currently has the fewest contested elections in the country, so most races are decided by 20% of the electorate.

All Party Primaries would reduce the red and blue and increase the green, where 64% of the electorate decides.

Every shift from red or blue to green increases the number of people and diversity of electorate deciding the election, a major participation gain.

Projecting the same percentage of contested general elections from Washington, Massachusetts shifts from **144 races with no general election competition** to **only 40** without a general election competition.

This is a dramatic increase in races where there are far more people with greater diversity deciding the election, a major participation gain.

Comparing States: Money In Campaigns

	California	Washington	Alaska	Massachusetts (projected with All Party Primaries)
All-party primary	Yes (top-two)	Yes (top-two)	Yes (top-four + RCV)	Yes (top-two)
Media costs	Very high	Moderate	Low	Moderate
Interest-group density	High	Moderate	Low	Moderate → increasing
Electoral competitiveness	High / variable	Moderate	Low–moderate	Moderate (↑ from low)
State contribution limits	$11,800 (leg); $78,400 Gov	$1,200	No limits	$1,000
Outside spending on elections growth after 2010	Very high	Moderate	Low	Currently minimal → projected moderate